

Playing PC games is good for you

Games of today are considered to be no-brainers with lots of shoot-em' up action involved. Everything that moves is shot at with an arsenal of weapons which would even put an army to shame. But this thought is in for some restructuring.

Studies of players and teams are showing that these games are much more complex and intriguing than most expectations. Scientific studies reveal the complex culture surrounding the games, as well as some reasons why people find them appealing. Professor Talmadge Wright and colleagues at Loyola University, Chicago, have spent hours studying *Counter-Strike* (a very popular *Half-Life* Mod) culture by taking part in games, interviewing players



and reviewing the text files of in-game text conversations.

Wright said the research shows that *Counter-Strike* is much more than gun-toting gameplay and raking up kills. He said the strategy and tactics used by many regular players and teams often makes it seem like a game of chess. The importance of the social side of *Counter-Strike* was revealed in the constant banter, in-game jokes and insults that people

exchanged during play.

Players tended to bring their offline culture with them when they play, with the most common emotion being laughter. The only reason that people could get away with insulting friends and foes was because they knew them so well, he said. People could live their fantasy roles which otherwise would not be possible. For this reason, and others, Wright believes that gaming is undoubtedly good for players.

Mobile chips get broadband-friendly

Australian researchers unveiled a chip that lets cellphone users receive high-quality face-to-face video and other streaming media at rates faster than a home broadband connection. The chip, developed by Bell Labs in Australia, works on a next-generation cellphone network and can run programs at up to 24 Megabits per second—almost 20 times faster than a traditional T1 line.

It lets users with wireless devices on a 3G network conduct video teleconferences, get corporate data, send and receive multimedia applications such as MP3 tones, video clips and slide show presentations. Analysts say that the chip could compete head-on with other WiFi wireless Internet networks, which have, of late, become hugely popular.

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Unreal security risk

PivX Solutions has announced that there are major flaws in the *Unreal* gaming engine, that could make your game server and client vulnerable to several fatal network attacks, including local and remote DoS attacks, execution of malicious code without size limitations, and more. Windows, Linux and Mac OS are equally vulnerable and playing a game on these platforms makes the user vulnerable to attack. Moreover, since the flaw is in the *Unreal* engine, all the games utilising the *Unreal* core are at risk. These include *Unreal Tournament*, *UT 2003*, *America's Army*, *Deus Ex* and as yet unreleased games such as *Navy Seals* and *Hired Guns*. PivX has posted a free tool that checks for malicious code within a system (www.pivx.com/luigi/mytoolz/unrcheck.zip).

Java and a virus hoax

Beware of an e-mail virus hoax that claims the executable file, *jdbgmgr.exe*, may be present on your hard drive. If it is, you are asked to delete it. The file *jdbgmgr.exe* is the Microsoft Debugger Registrar for Java, and it may or may not be present on your computer. Deleting this file may impair your system's normal functioning. So delete this e-mail hoax if you have received it, and do not open any .exe attachments that come with it. If you've already deleted your *jdbgmgr.exe* file, you can reinstall it from www.microsoft.com.

statattack

